

Pikachu plush returns from a space adventure

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Pikachu has been on quite a trip! A **plush** version of the Pokémon character spent 67 days on the International Space Station, according to the European Space Agency, or ESA.

The toy travelled to the station on a Cygnus **cargo spacecraft** on April 11. It returned to Earth aboard a SpaceX Dragon **cargo spacecraft** on June 17. **Cargo spacecraft** carry supplies and other items. During its stay, Pikachu made about 1,040 trips around Earth.

ESA revealed the adventure on September 19, 2026. The project was designed to help launch World Space Week, held from October 4 to 10 in 2026.

A special **exhibition** mixes Pokémon characters with real space science. Visitors can learn about European space **missions**, life on the station and studies of the Sun and Solar System.

The **exhibition** began in Paris in late September. It is planned to visit museums and other places across Europe through April 2027.

ESA hopes the little space traveller will encourage children and teenagers to become **curious** about science.

Word Treasure

plush -- A soft toy made from fabric.

cargo -- Supplies or other items carried by a vehicle.

spacecraft -- A vehicle that travels in space.

exhibition -- A collection of displays for people to visit.

missions -- Planned journeys or activities with a particular purpose.

curious -- Wanting to learn or find out more.

Background you need

Cargo spacecraft carry supplies and other items.

The exhibition introduces European space missions, space station life and studies of the Sun and Solar System.

Break it down

The opening introduces the plush toy's stay on the International Space Station.

The next paragraph describes its spacecraft journeys and trips around Earth.

The article links the project to World Space Week and explains the exhibition.

The ending gives the tour plans and ESA's hope of encouraging scientific curiosity.

Why it matters

The project connects a familiar character with information about space missions and life on the space station. ESA hopes this will encourage children and teenagers to explore science.

Test what you remember

1. Where did the Pikachu plush spend 67 days?
 - (A) On the surface of the Moon
 - (B) On the International Space Station
 - (C) At the exhibition in Paris
 - (D) At a museum in Europe
2. Which spacecraft carried Pikachu back to Earth?
 - (A) A Cygnus cargo spacecraft
 - (B) A spacecraft carrying passengers
 - (C) A SpaceX Dragon cargo spacecraft
 - (D) A spacecraft studying the Sun
3. About how many trips around Earth did Pikachu make?
 - (A) About 400 trips
 - (B) About 1,040 trips
 - (C) About 140 trips
 - (D) About 4,100 trips
4. When is World Space Week held in 2026?
 - (A) From April 4 to 10
 - (B) From October 4 to 10
 - (C) From June 4 to 10
 - (D) From September 4 to 10
5. What does the special exhibition combine?
 - (A) Pokémon characters and ocean science
 - (B) Pokémon characters and music history
 - (C) Pokémon characters and sports history
 - (D) Pokémon characters and space science
6. What does ESA hope the project will encourage?
 - (A) Children's curiosity about fashion
 - (B) Children's interest in music
 - (C) Children's interest in cooking
 - (D) Children's curiosity about science

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: B 4: B 5: D 6: D

Questions to think about

1. European Space Agency: ESA hopes the project will encourage children and teenagers to become curious about space and science.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):